

Checklist

Engineering Executive: Calibrating Your Standards

Self-Awareness: Audit Your Standards

- ☐ Am I consistently operating at a higher standard than my organization supports?
- ☐ Am I overworking to maintain standards that others don't share?
- ☐ Is my frustration about performance actually frustration about misaligned expectations?
- ☐ Are my standards helping me achieve long-term impact — or burning me out?

Diagnose Misalignment

- ☐ Does leadership knowingly tolerate a lower standard in this area?
- ☐ Is this a deliberate tradeoff (speed, cost, focus) rather than incompetence?
- ☐ Am I escalating a performance issue that leadership sees as acceptable?
- ☐ Am I unintentionally trying to hold the CEO accountable for a known but deprioritized issue?

Escalate Carefully

- ☐ Have I framed the issue as impact-driven rather than personal criticism?
- ☐ Have I considered that this disagreement reflects a difference in strategy?
- ☐ Am I escalating out of ethical obligation — or frustration?
- ☐ Do I understand that pushing too hard may label me as “difficult”?
- ☐ Am I prepared for slow change rather than immediate resolution?

Avoid the Burnout Trap

- ☐ Am I compensating for a peer's underperformance that management is unwilling to address?
- ☐ Am I grinding against constraints that realistically won't change?
- ☐ Is the penalty for lowering my standard here actually acceptable?
- ☐ Am I choosing battles that matter most?

Use Role Modeling Instead of Force

Model

- ☐ Have I clearly identified the area I want to improve?
- ☐ Am I demonstrating a high-standard approach visibly and consistently?
- ☐ Have I tested and refined the approach until it works well?

Document

- ☐ Have I written a clear, practical guide to the approach?
- ☐ Does it explain both *how* and *why*?
- ☐ Does it evaluate outcomes rather than assume superiority?

Share

- ☐ Have I shared the documented approach with interested teams?
- ☐ Am I engaging those who opt in?
- ☐ Am I letting go of teams that don't engage?

Adapt When Necessary

- ☐ What matters most at this moment — excellence, speed, stability, relationships?
- ☐ Is this a season where flexibility is more valuable than rigidity?
- ☐ Am I holding onto a "lesson not worth learning"?

- ☐ Are some penalties not worth paying?

Final Alignment Check

- ☐ Are my standards aligned with the organization's tolerances?
- ☐ Are my standards serving my long-term goals?
- ☐ Am I improving outcomes — or just winning arguments?
- ☐ Am I preserving relationships while maintaining integrity?